SIXTEEN

Air Chief Marshal Birender Singh Dhanoa (Param Vishisht Seva Medal, Ati Vishisht Seva Medal, Yudh Seva Medal, Vayu Sena Medal and Aide-De-Camp), the twenty-fifth chief of the air staff of the Indian Air Force from December 2016 to September 2019, addressed a gathering of pilots at the Indian Women Pilots' Association conference in Delhi three years ago. Srividya and I were invited to the conference and the air chief marshal reminisced about the one time he had been a passenger in a Cheetah helicopter flown by me.

June 1999

Wing Commander B.S. Dhanoa, a fighter pilot who was commanding a fighter squadron in Srinagar, had come on board my helicopter for an aerial recce of the forward area in Kargil. We were supposed to land in Kargil for an intelligence briefing before flying ahead. Dada came to know that I was arriving for the briefing, so he came to the tarmac to receive me.

'We've captured two peaks near Tiger Hill,' Dada exclaimed happily as he walked towards me on the tarmac.

'Congratulations to the army,' Wing Commander Dhanoa said to him as he got down from the helicopter. That's when Dada saw him and saluted. He saluted back.